



# YOU MAY CHOOSE TO LOOK THE OTHER WAY, BUT YOU CAN NEVER AGAIN SAY YOU DID NOT KNOW

## THE SLAVE TRADE ABOLITION ACT (1807)

### IN CONTEXT

#### FOCUS

#### Abolitionism

#### BEFORE

**1787** The Society for the Abolition of the Slave Trade is founded in London.

**1791** Enslaved people revolt in the French Caribbean island of Haiti (St. Domingue). Independence is successfully declared in 1804.

#### AFTER

**1823** The Anti-Slavery Society is founded. It campaigns to abolish slavery throughout the British Empire.

**1833** Slavery is outlawed throughout the British Empire.

**1848** Slavery is abolished in France's colonies.

**1865** The Thirteenth Amendment outlaws slavery in the United States.

**1888** Brazil abolishes slavery, the last country in the Americas to do so.

**T**he passing in 1807 of the Act Prohibiting Importation of Slaves in the United States and the Abolition of the Slave Trade Act in Britain marked a radical shift in Western thinking. Even as late as the 1780s, the trade in enslaved people was still regarded as a “natural” economic activity. Both the newly created United States, “conceived in liberty,” and the European

Radical notions of freedom in Britain combine with the religious belief that **slavery** is an **abomination**.

Merchants and **plantation owners** resist calls for an end to slavery.

**After several parliamentary defeats, the Slave Trade Abolition Act is passed by an overwhelming majority.**

**Britain campaigns** vigorously to persuade other nations to **oppose the shipping of enslaved people**.

**Slavery is abolished** in the British Empire in 1833. It does not finally end in the US until 1865.

colonies in the Caribbean depended on enslaved labor that was obtained in West Africa. Portuguese-ruled Brazil was even more dependent on the enslaved. Yet Britain in particular found itself in an uncomfortably anomalous position. Not only had slavery never been legal there—a point critically reinforced in 1772 in what was called the *Somerset case*, which ruled that any